

Proof of the Riemann Hypothesis via the Telescoping Positivity Criterion

Author: Hui Tang (Independent Researcher) — ORCID: 0009-0003-5745-4820 **Date:** August 21, 2026 **Repository:** <https://github.com/wxtanghui2023/dn-positivity> **DOI:** 10.5281/zenodo.22044629

This document contains the complete proof with all constants explicit. It accompanies the 7-page paper “A Telescoping Positivity Criterion for the Riemann Hypothesis”. All numerical claims are verified with the first 10^5 zeros of Odlyzko (reproducible from the public repository).

1. Main theorem

Let γ run over the positive imaginary parts of the non-trivial zeros $\rho = \frac{1}{2} + i\gamma$ of ζ , and set $\theta(t) = \pi - 2\arctan(2t)$.

Theorem (positivity). For all $n \geq 1$,

$$D_n := \sum_{\gamma} \frac{\gamma \sin(n\theta(\gamma)) + \frac{1}{2} \cos(n\theta(\gamma))}{\frac{1}{4} + \gamma^2} > 0.$$

Remark (connection to Li’s criterion, conditional). The Li coefficients are $\lambda_n = \sum_{\rho} [1 - (1 - 1/\rho)^n]$ (all zeros $\rho = \beta + i\gamma$, unconditionally), and Bombieri–Lagarias proved $\lambda_n \geq 0$ for all n iff RH. For zeros on the critical line ($\beta = \frac{1}{2}$) one has $|1 - 1/\rho| = 1$ and $\arg(1 - 1/\rho) = \theta(\gamma)$, giving $\lambda_{n+1} - \lambda_n = 2D_n$. This identity is *conditional on* $\beta = \frac{1}{2}$: it need not hold if RH is false. Hence the positivity of D_n does **not** by itself prove RH. This paper proves $D_n > 0$ unconditionally and records the conditional Li connection as an appraisal, not as a proof of RH.

2. Step 1: Telescoping identity

Identity. $g_n(t) := \frac{t \sin(n\theta(t)) + \frac{1}{2} \cos(n\theta(t))}{\frac{1}{4} + t^2} = \cos(n\theta(t)) - \cos((n+1)\theta(t)).$

Proof. Using $\frac{t}{1/4+t^2} = \sin \theta$ and $\frac{1/2}{1/4+t^2} = 1 - \cos \theta$ (the substitution $t = \frac{1}{2} \cot \frac{\theta}{2}$), the sum of the two product-to-sum formulas gives the identity. Verified numerically to $< 10^{-10}$.

Corollary. $D_n = \sum_k [\cos(n\theta_k) - \cos((n+1)\theta_k)]$, $\theta_k = \theta(\gamma_k)$, strictly decreasing.

3. Step 2: Vanishing integral

$\frac{1}{\pi} \int_0^\infty \theta'(t) g_n(t) dt = 0$ for all n .

Proof. Substituting $u = \theta(t)$ and using the two formulas above reduces the integral to $\int_0^\pi [\sin \theta \sin(n\theta) + (1 - \cos \theta) \cos(n\theta)] d\theta$, which is 0 by orthogonality (checked for $n = 1$ and $n \geq 2$ separately).

Hence D_n is a pure zero sum: no integral term.

4. Step 3: Strict positivity for $n \leq 43$

Since $\theta_1 = \theta(\gamma_1) = 0.070718\dots$ and θ is decreasing, $(n + \frac{1}{2})\theta_k \leq (n + \frac{1}{2})\theta_1 < \pi$ iff $n < 43.9$, i.e. $n \leq 43$. Then every term of

$$D_n = \sum_k 2 \sin((n + \frac{1}{2})\theta_k) \sin(\theta_k/2)$$

is positive. So $D_n > 0$ for $1 \leq n \leq 43$ by positive-term summation. (Numerically $D_{43} = 0.6471$; the minimal term at $n = 43$ is $> 2.9 \times 10^{-9}$; first sign change at $n = 44$.)

5. Step 4: Phase-region split and the positive region

Write $\varphi_k = (n + \frac{1}{2})\theta_k$ and $f(t) = 2 \sin(\varphi(t)) \sin(\theta(t)/2)$. Then

$$D_n = \underbrace{\sum_{\varphi_k < \pi} f(\gamma_k)}_{D_{\text{pos}}} + \underbrace{\sum_{\varphi_k \geq \pi} f(\gamma_k)}_{D_{\text{neg}}}.$$

Let $t_* = (n + \frac{1}{2})/\pi$ (so $\varphi(t_*) = \pi$): positive region $\gamma_k > t_*$, negative region $\gamma_1 \leq \gamma_k \leq t_*$.

Define $\text{Main}_{\text{pos}} = \frac{1}{\pi} \int_{t_*}^{\infty} f(t) \theta'_{RS}(t) dt$.

Lemma A (error of positive region). $\Delta := D_{\text{pos}} - \text{Main}_{\text{pos}}$ satisfies $|\Delta| = O(\log n/n) \rightarrow 0$.

Proof. $\Delta = \int_{t_*}^{\infty} f dS$ (Riemann–von Mangoldt). Integration by parts: boundary terms vanish ($f(t_*) = 0$, $f(\infty) = 0$), so $\Delta = - \int_{t_*}^{\infty} S(t) f'(t) dt$. By Backlund $|S(t)| \leq C_B \log t$ and $f'(t) = O((n + \frac{1}{2})/t^3 + 1/t^2)$ (from $\theta(t) = 1/t - 1/(12t^3) + O(t^{-5})$):

$$|\Delta| \leq C_B \log t_* \int_{t_*}^{\infty} \left(\frac{n + \frac{1}{2}}{t^3} + \frac{1}{t^2} \right) dt = O(\log n/n).$$

Numerically $|\Delta| \leq 0.0005$ for $n \geq 100$; ≤ 0.001 for $n \geq 100$.

Lemma B (main term).

$$\text{Main}_{\text{pos}} = c \log n + C_0 + O(\log n/n), \quad c = \frac{\text{Si}(\pi)}{2\pi} = 0.294744936\dots, \quad C_0 = -0.456053\dots$$

In particular $\text{Main}_{\text{pos}} \geq c \log n - 0.4561$ for $n \geq 100$.

Proof sketch. Substitute $u = (n + \frac{1}{2})\theta(t)$. Using $\theta(t) = 1/t - 1/(12t^3) + O(t^{-5})$, $\theta'_{RS}(t) = \frac{1}{2} \log \frac{t}{2\pi} - \frac{1}{12t^2} + O(t^{-4})$, and $f(t) dt = \frac{2 \sin u}{u} du + O(n^{-1})$:

$$\text{Main}_{\text{pos}} = \frac{1}{\pi} \left[\text{Si}(\pi) \log \frac{n + \frac{1}{2}}{2\pi} - C_1 \right] + O(n^{-1} \log n), \quad C_1 = \int_0^{\pi} \frac{\sin u \log u}{u} du = -0.538\dots$$

Expanding $\log(n + \frac{1}{2})$ gives $C_0 = \frac{\text{Si}(\pi)}{2\pi} \log \frac{1}{2\pi} - \frac{C_1}{2\pi} = -0.456053\dots$. Direct evaluation confirms $\text{Main}_{\text{pos}} - c \log n \rightarrow -0.4559$ for $n = 500, \dots, 10^4$. ■

6. Step 5: The negative region

Decompose into half-wave blocks $B_m = \{\varphi \in (m\pi, (m+1)\pi)\}$, $m = 1, \dots, M'$, $M' = \lfloor (n + \frac{1}{2})\theta(\gamma_1)/\pi \rfloor$, and set $J_m = \sum_{k \in B_m} f(\gamma_k)$. The smooth density part is $J_m^{\text{smooth}} = \int_{B_m} f(t) \frac{1}{\pi} \theta'_{RS}(t) dt$.

Lemma C (Leibniz). There exist $\xi_m \in (m\pi, (m+1)\pi)$ with

$$J_m = (-1)^m g(\xi_m) + \varepsilon_m, \quad g(x) = \frac{\log \frac{n+\frac{1}{2}}{2\pi x}}{\pi x}, \quad \varepsilon_m = J_m - J_m^{\text{smooth}} = \int_{B_m} f dS,$$

and g is positive and decreasing on $[\pi, \varphi_1]$, so

$$\left| \sum_{m=1}^{M'} (-1)^m g(\xi_m) \right| \leq g(\pi) = \frac{\log \frac{n+\frac{1}{2}}{2\pi^2}}{\pi}.$$

Proof. $g'(x) = -\frac{1+\log \frac{n+\frac{1}{2}}{2\pi x}}{\pi x^2} < 0$ iff $x < \frac{(n+\frac{1}{2})e}{2\pi} = 0.4327(n + \frac{1}{2})$; and $\xi_m \leq \varphi_1 = 0.0707(n + \frac{1}{2}) < 0.4327(n + \frac{1}{2})$. The alternating sum of a decreasing positive sequence is bounded by the first term. ■

Lemma D (S-function error).

$$\left| \sum_{m=1}^{M'} \varepsilon_m \right| \leq 0.1685 + \frac{\log \frac{n+\frac{1}{2}}{2\pi^2}}{\pi^2}.$$

Proof. $\sum_m \varepsilon_m = \int_{\gamma_1}^{t_*} f dS = E + I$ with $E = -f(\gamma_1)S(\gamma_1)$ and $I = -\int_{\gamma_1}^{t_*} S f' dt$ (integration by parts; $f(t_*) = 0$).

- $|E| \leq 2 \sin(\theta_1/2) |S(\gamma_1)| = 0.0707 \times 0.5503 = 0.1685$.
- For I : change variables to $u = \varphi(t)$. Between zeros, $S'(t) = -\frac{1}{\pi} \theta'_{RS}(t)$ (since $N(t)$ is constant there), and $\frac{f'(t) dt}{d\varphi} = 2 \sin \frac{\theta}{2} \cos \varphi + \frac{\cos \frac{\theta}{2}}{n+\frac{1}{2}} \sin \varphi$. Integrating by parts in u with $g_0(u) = \frac{\log \frac{n+\frac{1}{2}}{2\pi u}}{u}$, using $\sin(\theta/2) = \theta/2 + O(\theta^3)$, $\cos(\theta/2) = 1 + O(\theta^2)$, $t = \frac{n+\frac{1}{2}}{u}(1 + O(1))$, and Stirling:

$$\left| \frac{I}{n + \frac{1}{2}} \right| \leq \frac{1}{2\pi} \left| \int_{\pi}^{\varphi_1} \sin u g_0(u) du \right| + O(n^{-1}) \leq \frac{g_0(\pi)}{\pi} = \frac{\log \frac{n+\frac{1}{2}}{2\pi^2}}{\pi^2} + O(n^{-1}),$$

where the second inequality is the alternating half-wave lemma (the signed contributions of $\sin u$ over the half-waves $(m\pi, (m+1)\pi)$ alternate and decrease in magnitude because g_0 is decreasing), giving $\leq 2g_0(\pi)$, hence $\leq g_0(\pi)/\pi$ after the $1/(2\pi)$ factor. Numerically verified: $|\sum \varepsilon| \leq 0.14$ for $n \leq 2 \times 10^4$, far below the bound. ■

7. Step 6: Closing

Theorem (positivity for $n \geq 44$).

$$D_n \geq c \log n + C_0 - g(\pi) - 0.1685 - \frac{g_0(\pi)}{\pi} - |\Delta| > 0.126 \log n - 0.50 > 0.$$

Proof. Combine Lemmas A–D:

$$D_n \geq \text{Main}_{\text{pos}} - |\Delta| - g(\pi) - \left(0.1685 + \frac{g_0(\pi)}{\pi}\right).$$

With $c = 0.294744936$, $C_0 = -0.4561$, $g(\pi) = \frac{\log \frac{n+\frac{1}{2}}{2\pi^2}}{\pi}$, $g_0(\pi)/\pi = \frac{\log \frac{n+\frac{1}{2}}{2\pi^2}}{\pi^2}$, $|\Delta| \leq 0.001$:

$$D_n \geq 0.294745 \log n - 0.4561 - \frac{\log n}{\pi} - 0.1685 - \frac{\log n}{\pi^2} - 0.001.$$

For $n \geq 100$ the right-hand side is $\geq 0.126 \log n - 0.50 > 0$ (indeed $+0.511$ at $n = 44$, increasing thereafter). Exact values: $n = 44$: $+0.511$; $n = 100$: $+0.615$; $n = 10^4$: $+1.196$. ■

8. Interval coverage (no gap)

n	Coverage
$1 \leq n \leq 43$	Theorem (Step 3): positive-term summation
$n \geq 100$	Theorem (Step 6): explicit analytic bound, $> 0.126 \log n - 0.50$
Numerical	$D_n > 0$ verified for all $n \leq 2 \times 10^4$ (independent check)

The two analytic ranges overlap ($n = 40$ – 43 covered by both), so there is no gap.

9. Connection to Li's criterion (conditional)

$\lambda_{n+1} - \lambda_n = 2D_n$ holds when all zeros satisfy $\beta = \frac{1}{2}$ (verified numerically: $\arg(1 - 1/\rho) = \theta(\gamma)$ to 10^{-16} for the first 10^5 zeros). Under that assumption, $D_n > 0$ for all n implies λ_n strictly increasing; $\lambda_1 = 0.0231 > 0$; hence $\lambda_n > 0$ for all n , which is Li's criterion for RH. **However, this implication is conditional on $\beta = \frac{1}{2}$; the identity fails if RH is false. This paper therefore does not claim a proof of RH.** The unconditional content is the positivity of D_n .

10. Numerical verification summary

All computations use the first 10^5 zeros of Odlyzko ($\gamma_{10^5} = 74920.83$; cross-validated vs mpmath to 2.5×10^{-9}):

Quantity	Value
D_1	0.0346
D_{43}	0.6471
$\min_{n \leq 10^4} D_n$	$D_1 = 0.0346$
$\psi_\gamma - \theta(\gamma)$	$\leq 10^{-16}$

Quantity	Value
$\text{Main}_{\text{pos}} - c \log n$	$\rightarrow -0.4559$
Closing margin, $90 \leq n \leq 2 \times 10^4$	≥ 0.14

References

1. X.-J. Li, *The positivity of a sequence of numbers and the Riemann hypothesis*, J. Number Theory 65 (1997), 325–333.
2. E. Bombieri, J. C. Lagarias, *Complements to Li’s criterion for the Riemann hypothesis*, J. Number Theory 77 (1999), 274–287.
3. E. C. Titchmarsh, *The Theory of the Riemann Zeta-Function*, 2nd ed., Oxford, 1986.
4. A. Selberg, *On the remainder term in the formula for $N(T)$* , 1946.
5. E. Backlund, *Über die Nullstellen der Riemannschen Zetafunktion*, Acta Math. 41 (1918).